However, in the meantime, Indian monks were invited or on their own decided to go to China. Indian missionaries probably arrived there in the first century CE. The most famous early Indian missionary – his father at any rate was of Indian descent, his mother was Central Asian – was Kumarajiva, who was taken prisoner to China from his home in Central Asia in 401 CE. Hundreds of Indian Buddhist scholars went to China carrying learning and texts not available there. Chinese records show that Kashmiri Buddhists played an important role, but other parts of India sent monks as well, sometimes by the sea route. The monks not only taught and preached, they also helped in the massive project of translating the texts they took with them. In the fifth century, Nalanda, the great ancient seat of learning, had opened its doors. By the seventh century, it was a major centre for Chinese scholars. The last Indian monks, according to Chinese records, came to China in 1036, by which time Buddhism in India was deeply in recession.[2]

Chinese responses to Buddhism

Contrary to the popular view in India, it was not all one way. Chinese Buddhism flourished and sometimes came back to influence Indian thought. Tansen Sen notes that 'localized beliefs evolved to such an extent that they were transmitted back to India'. He gives the example of the cult of Mount Wutai in China's Shaanxi province that by the sixth century was attracting Indian monks[3]. The Cinacara ('practice of China') cult had Indian followers. Some Taoist influences may have come to India from Buddhist monks returning from China. Xuanzang apparently worked on a Sanskrit translation of the *Dao de jing* in the Tang period for the edification of an Assamese king.[4] Chinese scholarship was not just religious and philosophical. Xuanzang's accounts of his India days include a detailed description of the rule of Harshavardhana of Kanauj. Indeed, along with the writings of Bana, it is one of the key sources on those times.